

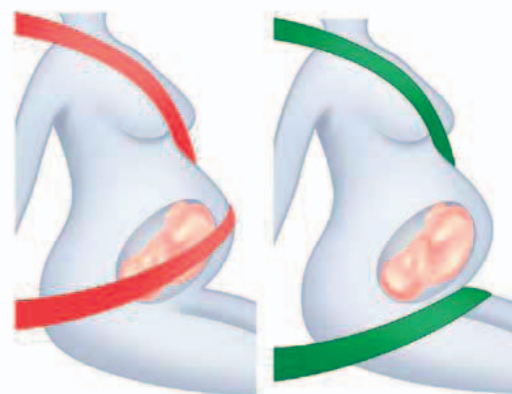
Q I'm planning to drive rather than fly to my vacation destination. Can you give me advice on long car trips?

First, always wear your seat belt: put the lap strap under your abdomen, across your thighs, and over the top of your abdomen. Adjust your seat a little or invest in a cushioning pad if the strap cuts into your neck.

If you're driving and find the driving seat a squeeze, tilt the steering wheel back if you can, or recline your seat slightly to give you more space. Never move your seat backward so much that you can't reach the pedals properly and always make sure you can still see over the top of the steering wheel. If you adjust your seat, don't forget to adjust your mirrors, too. Take frequent rest and bathroom breaks. Sitting in the

same position for long periods of time can be uncomfortable during pregnancy. When you get out of the car, swing your legs out first, and try not to twist awkwardly. Push up from a seated position using your thighs rather than your back.

Comfort in the car Three-point seat belts with the straps placed above and below your belly will allow you to feel comfortable, while still being safe.



INCORRECT POSITION

CORRECT POSITION

vacations—not only because of the altitude (you should not go more than 6,500 ft/2,000 m above sea level), but because of the risk for impact, too. Walking vacations on low, gently undulating foothills, or forest or seaside walks could be good for you, especially during your second trimester, but don't make each day's activity any more strenuous than your pregnant body can deal with. Take frequent rest stops. If you are going to a sunny climate or intending to be outside frequently, always practice good sun safety by wearing a high-SPF, broad-spectrum sunscreen that doesn't contain oxybenzone (a chemical linked to low birth weights).

Q Is it safe to have vacation vaccinations while I'm pregnant?

Most vaccinations are made using small amounts of the disease you're vaccinating against, so in general it's better to avoid going to countries that require you to have immunizations. In addition, avoid malaria-risk countries. Although there are malaria medications that are safe to take during pregnancy, malaria itself poses a high risk of death for

you and your baby. If you can't avoid traveling to a high-risk country, talk to your doctor well in advance about the immunizations you'll need and, if relevant, about malaria pills. On balance it's usually better to vaccinate than risk contracting disease, but you should always seek individualized medical advice.

Q Should I get special travel insurance that covers treatment for my pregnancy?

You won't necessarily need pregnancy-specific travel insurance, but check your policy to see what pregnancy issues are covered. Look for what will happen if you go into labor, have to cancel your vacation because of a pregnancy-related issue, or you need repatriating. Make sure your insurer knows that you're pregnant before you travel and that you are complying with any stipulations that keep your cover safe, such as carrying a letter or certificate from your doctor to say you're fit to travel. Some insurers won't cover you if you travel beyond a certain week of pregnancy, which may be different from the week the airline stipulates, and often insurers don't cover the neonatal period, for example if your baby is born early and needs medical care.

Bring your **medical records** when you go on vacation so that any doctor **treating** you knows your pregnancy **history** and can take care of you safely.

